

spare time. We have some people paid by us but their role is to reach out to the openSUSE community and make sure that our core engineering team and their engineering community are well-aligned and synchronised. We know that there is voluntary and unorganised participation going on but sometimes we need to know what are they working on and how we can synchronise our efforts. So, in a nutshell, there are people paid to build a link between openSUSE and SUSE. On top of that, we give them some funding and marketing support as well.

Q You have joined the OpenStack cloud project like Canonical and Red Hat. Was that a strategic move?

Nils: Yes, very much. We heard from our customers that they are considering building a private cloud. Seeing that demand, we wanted to find out whether they would be happy to consider powering their cloud with open source. We spoke to some of our enterprise customers and we got some fairly positive responses. They wanted open source not only as an operating system but as a choice to power their private cloud initiatives. So we got a confirmation that there is a future for private clouds and second, enterprises are ready to consider open source as their option. After we got a go-ahead from all corners, we thought about which open source community to join. And we looked at the community which had the most momentum, the biggest industry support, and the biggest community because if the community is large, many people contribute and the development process is faster. We finally found the last missing piece—that was OpenStack. We then committed to be the platinum sponsors for the OpenStack Foundation for the next five years.

Q You said that you are banking big on the enterprise space. Linux is already big in the enterprise space. Is SUSE trying to leverage on Linux's popularity or is the company trying to play safe because you are not talking of the desktop space or even the mobile space—which is a hot property these days?

Nils: We are not thinking of the mobile space at all. The mobile space is pretty much taken over by the other vendors and I don't think there is anything much left for SUSE to come up with in this space. So it is the enterprise space. We offer enterprise server solutions and enterprise desktops as well. So if you talk about reaching out to consumers straight away, we have enterprise desktops which we sell to our enterprise customers. We are also one of the largest contributors to the LibreOffice open source project. LibreOffice is a desktop product as well and we are selling LibreOffice to enterprises to run on SUSE Linux enterprise desktops and also to run on Windows' desktops. So we are targeting the desktop space and investing in the cloud space as well.

Venkatesh: If you look at the initiatives from the Indian

government and most of the state governments, they have mandated that any technology that is to be purchased for the government initiatives would be predominantly on an open source platform. So organisations like ELCOT have been significant buyers of our desktops over a number of years and they will continue to be a significant partner for us in the desktop space. We are also beginning to see a lot of initiatives from the Odisha, West Bengal and North Eastern state governments. A lot of state governments are also looking to provide laptops to their students. So we are working on getting those laptops run on our SUSE desktop offerings. So you would see a lot of momentum and a lot of adoption in government initiatives in the desktop space.

Q The UP government is also planning to distribute laptops and tablets to students. Are you in talks with them as well?

Venkatesh: Yes we are. As we speak, we are engaging with the partners because we want to figure out what their expectations are. Every government is unique, the pricing patterns are unique, the usage patterns and education systems are also very unique. So we are still figuring out the many aspects of this venture.

Q Since you are talking of the desktop space, let's talk about Windows 8 as well. Have you had an experience with it and what is your opinion about it?

Venkatesh: Yes, I did get an opportunity to try the operating system. It looks nice and very different from what Windows 7 was or, for that matter, any other earlier version of Windows. But the fact that it will offer a similar experience on the desktop and mobile space, will be something good for the consumers.

Q How do you see that in terms of competition?

Venkatesh: I would not deny that the company has done great work in terms of making it easy for users. I think this would definitely change the way devices are experienced.

Q Will the next version of SUSE desktop be inspired by Windows 8?

Venkatesh: I think open source communities are appreciative of good technology work done in all the domains. We definitely keep a watch on the products, but I wouldn't comment on whether Windows 8 will inspire us in the development of upcoming versions.

Q What are your plans for involving developers in India and do you plan to replicate some of the global programmes in India as well?

Nils: This is one of the constant conversations we have in the company. We do not mind replicating some of our successful models but we want to be close enough to the local market and local developers, and customise our programmes to suit their needs. **END** 